



Visa & Work Permits

A Foreigner's Complete Guide to Work Permits & Visas for



China (2025-2026)

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Foreigners who wish to work in China must obtain a Foreigner's Work Permit and a work-type residence permit before they can legally begin working. This guide explains the complete process -- from who qualifies, to how to apply, what documents you need, and what to do after you arrive.

Important Update (2025-2026):

The physical Foreigner's Work Permit card has been discontinued. Work permit information is now integrated into the Social Security Card (电子社保卡) for foreign employees.

1. Who Needs a Work Permit?



<blockquote>"Foreigners working in China must obtain a work permit and a work-type residence permit in accordance with regulations. No employer may hire a foreigner who has not obtained a work permit and a work-type residence permit." -- Exit and Entry Administration Law of the PRC, Article 41</blockquote>

The work permit is required for

any foreign national working in China

(including teaching, business management, technical roles, research, etc.), regardless of

the duration or type of employment.

* Work permits are handled by the

* employer

* (the hiring company/institution), not by the foreigner personally. However, you will

need to provide all required documents and cooperate throughout the process.

* The permit is granted to the employer for a specific position --

* not to you as an individual

* . If you change employers or job roles, you must reapply.

2. Three Categories of Foreign Workers (A / B / C)

China classifies foreign workers into three categories based on skills, experience, and national needs.

Category	Who it applies
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Key features

A类 - Foreign High-End Talent

Scientists, tech leaders, top executives, special experts, etc.	No
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age/education limits; "green channel" processing; 2-5 years validity; fewer document

requirements; no numeric limits.

B类 - Foreign Professionals

Bachelor's degree + ≥ 2 years relevant work experience; age ≤ 60 ; roles
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needed for economic development

Numeric limits based on market demand;
standard documentation; some flexibility for startup talent and outstanding foreign graduates.

C类 - Other Foreign Personnel

Seasonal workers, interns, and other roles defined by policy	Strict numeric limits; subject to government quota.
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Points-based system:

B-class applicants are assessed via a points system (minimum 60 points) based on factors like salary, Chinese language ability, and work experience.

3. Basic Eligibility Requirements (All Categories)

* Age ≥ 18 years

* Good health (no serious infectious diseases)

* No criminal record



* A confirmed employer in China

* Possess the necessary professional skills or qualifications for the job

* The job must align with China's economic development needs

4. Step-by-Step Application Process (for Work Periods >90 Days)

Step 1 -- Employer registers an account online

Your employer must first register on the

Foreigners' Work Management Service System (外国人来华工作管理服务系统)

. The employer needs to provide their business license, Unified Social Credit Code

certificate, and legal representative details. If your employer does not know how to do

this, they can engage a licensed agency to handle it on their behalf.

Step 2 -- Online application for the Work Permit Notification



Your employer submits the application and all required documents online to the local Foreign Experts Bureau or relevant government department. Processing time: about 5 working days

. If documents are incomplete, the agency will notify the employer to make corrections.

Step 3 -- Obtain the Work Permit Notification

If approved, the system generates a "Notification Letter of Foreigner's Work Permit"

(外国人工作许可通知). This document is

valid for 3 months

from the date of issue. ! The Notification Letter is

not

a visa and cannot be used in place of one.

Step 4 -- Apply for a Z-visa at a Chinese embassy/consulate



Present the following at the nearest Chinese embassy or consulate in your home country:

- * Notification Letter of Foreigner's Work Permit

- * Valid passport (at least 6 months validity remaining)

- * Passport photo

- * Visa application form

The embassy/consulate will issue a

Z-visa

(for foreign employees). In special cases,

R-visas

(for high-end talent) or

F-visas

may be issued.



Step 5 -- Enter China and apply for the physical Work Permit

Within

15 days

of entering China, you (via your employer) must apply to obtain the Foreigner's Work

Permit (now integrated into the Social Security Card system). Submit all original

documents for verification (original degree certificates, no criminal record certificate,

health check report, employment contract). Processing time: about

10 working days

(A-class may be processed faster).

Step 6 -- Apply for a work-type residence permit

Within

30 days



of entry, you must go to the local Public Security Bureau's (PSB) Exit-Entry

Administration Department to apply for a work-type residence permit.

Required documents:

- * Passport with Z-visa

- * Foreigner's Work Permit

- * Employment contract

- * Completed residence permit application form

- * Passport photo

Processing time: Typically

15 working days

(can be processed together with the work permit at "single window" service counters in many cities).

!

You cannot begin working until you have both the Work Permit and the work-type residence permit in hand.

5. Required Documents -- Complete List

<table class="guide-table">

<thead><tr><th>Document</th><th>Notes</th></tr></thead> <tbody>

<tr><td>Foreigner's Work Permit Application Form</td><td>Completed online, printed, signed, and stamped with employer's seal. Submitted electronically.</td></tr>

<tr><td>Work Experience Certificate</td><td>Issued by previous employer(s); includes position, dates of employment, and contact details. Must bear the employer's seal or

signature.</td></tr> <tr><td>Highest Academic Degree/Diploma</td><td>Must be

notarized and authenticated by Chinese embassy/consulate in the country of issue, or

by apostille certification if the issuing country is a party to the Apostille Convention.

A-class applicants may submit via letter of commitment.	No Criminal Record Certificate
Issued by police or judicial authorities of your home country. Must be authenticated by Chinese embassy/consulate and dated within the last 6 months. A-class applicants may submit a letter of commitment.	
Health Check Certificate	Issued by a Chinese quarantine authority or an overseas medical institution recognized by Chinese authorities. Must be dated within 6 months.
Employment Contract	Must be in Chinese, signed by both parties, and bear the employer's official seal. Must include: job location, job description, salary, start date, and term of employment.
Passport	Must be valid for at least 6 months.
Passport Photo	White background, taken within last 6 months; JPG format, 40-120KB.
Chinese Translation of Non-Chinese Documents	All documents not originally in Chinese must be accompanied by a Chinese translation, stamped with the employer's official seal (except for the

passport).

A-class applicants enjoy reduced documentation requirements (e.g., no criminal record certificate may be submitted via a letter of commitment, no need for physical document verification on arrival).

6. Special Case -- Applying While Already in China (A-class Applicants)

If you are already in China legally (e.g., on a business, tourist, or family visa),

A-class applicants

may apply for the work permit directly from inside China without leaving to obtain a

Z-visa overseas. This is

not allowed

for B-class or C-class applicants unless you fall under other narrow exceptions (e.g.,

transferring between employers without changing job duties, family members of

Chinese citizens or permanent residents, etc.).

! Even for A-class applicants, the work-type residence permit must still be obtained after the work permit is approved.

You cannot work on a tourist or business visa.

7. How Long Does It Take?

Stage	Approximate processing time
Online pre-approval (Notification Letter)	5 working days
Decision on work permit application	20 working days (can be extended by 10 days)
Work permit (after arrival in China)	10 working days
Work-type residence permit	15 working days

Total estimated time

(overseas application to full approval): Approximately

2-3 months

, depending on document preparation and embassy/consulate visa processing times.

8. Visa Types Explained

Visa Code	Name	Who it
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applies to	When to use

Z

	Work visa	Standard work permit holders	Most foreign
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	employees
--	-----------

R

	Talent visa	A-class high-end talent with special
--	-------------	--------------------------------------

	skills	High-end talent; faster processing
--	--------	------------------------------------

F

	Non-commercial visit visa	Short-term work permits (≤90
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days)</td><td>Short-term work/project visits</td></tr> </tbody> </table>

9. Important Legal Notes

- * The work permit

- * cannot be transferred

- * to another employer. If you change companies, you must cancel the existing work permit and apply for a new one.

- * The work permit is

- * not a visa

- * . You must still obtain the appropriate visa (Z/R/F) from a Chinese embassy or consulate before traveling to China.

- * You

- * cannot work

- * until both the Work Permit and the work-type residence permit have been approved.



* Failure to obtain both permits before starting work constitutes

* illegal employment

* and can result in fines, deportation, and a ban on re-entry.

* Your employer must apply for work permit extension

* at least 30 days before

* it expires.

* Changes to personal information (name, passport number, job position, etc.) must be

reported and the work permit amended

* within 10 working days

* of the change.

* If your employment contract is terminated early, your employer must cancel your work

permit

* within 10 working days



* of termination.

10. Official Systems and Contact Points

* Main online system:

* Foreigners' Work Management Service System

* Customer service hotline:

* 12333 (National Human Resources and Social Security hotline)

* Local PSB Exit-Entry Administration:

* For work-type residence permit inquiries

* Chinese embassy/consulate:

* For Z/R/F visa applications in your home country

* Document authentication:

* China Consular Service website

* Official guidelines PDF:



* State Administration of Foreign Experts Affairs -- Work Permit Guidelines (2017)

11. Summary Checklist -- Quick Reference

Secure a job offer from a legally established Chinese employer.

Employer registers on the

Foreigners' Work Management Service System

.

Employer submits online application with all documents (work experience certificate, diploma, no criminal record certificate, health check, contract, etc.).

Receive Notification Letter (valid for 3 months).

Apply for Z-visa (or R/F) at Chinese embassy/consulate in your home country.

Enter China (within the visa validity period).



Within 15 days of entry, employer submits original documents for verification to obtain Work Permit.

Within 30 days of entry, apply at local PSB for work-type residence permit.

Begin work legally -- only after both permits are approved.

Ensure permits are extended or amended as required during your stay.

12. Frequently Asked Questions (FAQ)

Q: Can I apply for a work permit without an employer?

A: No. The work permit is tied to a specific employer and position. You must have a confirmed job offer before applying.

Q: Can I start working once I receive my Z-visa?



A: No. You must also obtain the Foreigner's Work Permit (upon arrival in China) and the work-type residence permit before you can legally work.

Q: Do I need a work permit if I am teaching English for just three months?

A: Yes. Any work in China -- paid or unpaid -- requires a work permit and work-type residence permit. Short-term work (≤ 90 days) can be done under an F-visa with a shorter work permit, but this still requires formal approval.

Q: Can I bring my family?

A: Yes. Spouses and children may apply for S-visas or dependent residence permits. They are not automatically included in your work permit -- separate applications are required.

Q: Do I need a Chinese bank account to apply?

A: Not directly, but your employer will need to provide proof of your salary (for the



points system) and may need a bank account for 社保 contributions.

Q: What if I already have a work permit but change jobs?

A: Your current work permit must be cancelled, and you (or your new employer) must

reapply from scratch -- even if you are staying in the same field.

Sources: Sources: [Foreigners' Work Management Service](https://fwp.safea.gov.cn/lhgzweb)

System

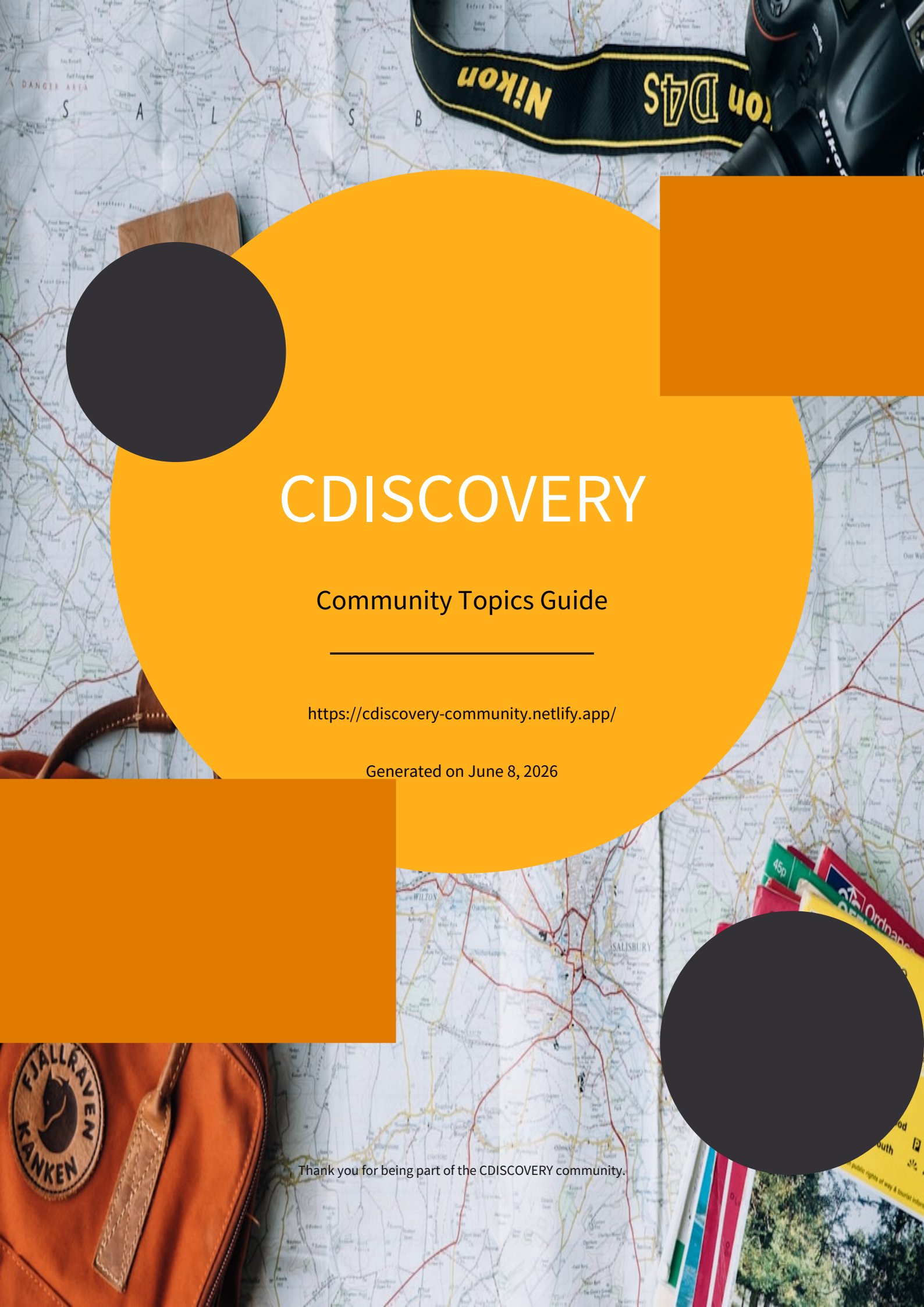
- [SAFEA Work Permit Guidelines \(2017\)](https://www.safea.gov.cn/r/cms/zwpt/web/pdf/wgrlhq/20170418182639_469.pdf)

- [China Consular Service](http://www.cs.mfa.gov.cn)

- [Ministry of Human](http://www.mohrss.gov.cn)

Resources

- Exit and Entry Administration Law of the PRC, Article 41



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Generated on June 8, 2026

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